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HD MediaPlayers

Have an HDTV, but no access to HD channels? Want to access the net on your non-smart TV? Read on...

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Have a lot of HD movies on your external drive and your HDTV won't play certain formats? Want to access the internet, but don't have a smart TV? Well, in that case, investing in an HD media player is your best bet. And I will tell you how you go about doing that.

The case for HD media players

First up, the very basic premise of this device is to play video files off any USB storage – portable hard drives, pen drives, whatever you may have stored the files on. Most media players can playback almost all the popular video formats, but some are more capable than others. Secondly, the player uses complex algorithms to upscale the resolution of the video being played back, on the fly. Simply put, your low-res media will be processed to enhance the quality on higher res screens. Most HD media players will let you set the maximum resolution for the upscaling process – 720p or 1080p. In essence, these devices act as the perfect go-between for your HDTV and the media you may have on your drive. The main purpose of the device is to playback video and that is what it does best. It can render your old DVD or Blu-Ray drive redundant because of the media capability it offers.

Will they play all my video files?

These devices will handle most of the video formats you throw their way; the popular ones being – AVI, MP4, MKV

and WMV. Within these formats, there may be containers that may be incompatible, but by and large, everything is well configured. If you want a media player that plays back all video formats you throw at it without any hassle, the likes of the WD Live (2012 update), the Seagate GoFlex TV and the Asus O! Play Air are some of the really good options among the ones we have tested. These three are available in the ₹6,500 to ₹8,000 price bracket, and will even let you access certain web services and stream content on the network thanks to its integrated Wi-Fi.

What else can they do?

Most mid-range and high-end media players will be able to connect to the web, either via a LAN connection, an optional



Wi-Fi dongle or integrated wireless adapter. You can access apps, play games, view web services, stream content from services like Live 365 and Deezer, watch YouTube and even download movie information in some cases. If online services matter a lot to you, we recommend the D-Link Boxee Box. It is a premium product, and costs around ₹10,500, with the widest range of web services packaged as apps. Alternatively, the Portronics LimeBox (around ₹10,000) is an Android based HD media player, which allows you to use a rather good browser, and pick from a huge range of apps. Speaking of which, the Amkette Evo TV (₹12,000) is also one such option, with a slicker interface and motion control remote offering a unique user experience.

Which are the best ones to buy?

There is a fair amount of variety within this category. For a basic device that also does wireless streaming and a bit of web apps, the WD Live makes perfect sense. If you also want the flexibility of playback along with a better plethora of web apps and services, the D-Link Boxee Box for around ₹10,500 is a better bet. You get a fairly geeky user interface, but it is very usable once you get the hang of it.

The WD Live Hub has been in the market for a while now, but offers something most others don't – a 1TB hard drive built-in. This one does miss out on integrated Wi-Fi, but has the same robust media playback capabilities of the WD Live. **[1]**